

Reading and Writing English (B21EG01LC)

A clear, exam-prep study guide expanding on your syllabus points with simple explanations and examples.

Block 1 — Communication

1. Communication Model

Every act of communication has four basic parts:

- **Sender** – the person who starts the message
- **Message** – the actual information being shared
- **Receiver** – the person who gets the message
- **Feedback** – the receiver's response, which tells the sender if the message was understood

Example: A teacher (sender) explains a topic (message) to students (receiver); students nodding or asking questions is the feedback.

2. Communication Styles

Style	What it looks like	Effect
Aggressive	Loud, dominating, disrespects others	Creates conflict
Passive	Avoids expressing opinions, gives in	Needs go unmet
Passive-Aggressive	Indirect resentment, sarcasm	Confusing, damages trust
Assertive 	Honest, respectful, clear about needs	Best style — respects self and others

3. Encoding & Decoding

- **Encoding** = the sender turns their idea into words/symbols/gestures
- **Decoding** = the receiver interprets those symbols to understand the idea

Think of it like a radio: encoding = converting sound to a signal; decoding = the receiver's radio converting the signal back to sound.

4. Non-Verbal Communication Types

- **Haptics** – communication through touch (handshake, pat on the back)
- **Proxemics** – use of physical space/distance (standing close vs far)

- **Chronemics** - use of time (being on time = respect; lateness = a message too)
- **Kinesics** - body movements and gestures (nodding, pointing)
- **Vocalics** - tone, pitch, and quality of voice (not the words, but *how* they're said)

5. Formal Communication Flows (in organizations)

- **Vertical** - flows up and down (boss → employee or employee → boss)
- **Horizontal** - flows between people at the same level (colleague to colleague)
- **Diagonal** - flows across different levels and departments (e.g., a junior marketing employee to a senior finance manager)

6. Communication by Number of People Involved

- **Intrapersonal** - communication within yourself (self-talk, thinking)
- **Dyadic** - between two people (a conversation)
- **Small Group** - among a few people (team meeting)
- **Public** - one speaker to a large audience (a speech)
- **Mass** - reaching very large audiences through media (TV, newspapers)

7. Qualities of Good Communication (the 7 C's)

- **Clear** - easy to understand
- **Correct** - accurate, no errors
- **Complete** - has all necessary information
- **Concise** - short and to the point
- **Concrete** - specific, not vague
- **Courteous** - polite and respectful
- **Considerate** - keeps the receiver's perspective in mind

8. Barriers to Communication (10 types)

1. **Physical** - noise, distance, poor connection
2. **Physiological** - hearing/speech problems, illness
3. **Psychological** - stress, fear, prejudice
4. **Linguistic** - language differences, jargon
5. **Perceptual** - different interpretations of the same message
6. **Cultural** - differing customs and values
7. **Organisational** - rigid hierarchy, unclear policies
8. **Gender** - differing communication styles between genders
9. **Emotional** - anger, anxiety clouding the message
10. **Mechanical** - faulty equipment (bad phone line, technical glitch)

9. Grapevine

The **informal communication network** in a workplace — the unofficial "gossip channel" (e.g., coffee-break talk). It travels fast but has no fixed, official channel, so it can be inaccurate.

Block 2 — Reading

1. Two Categories of Reading

- **Extensive reading** - reading widely for pleasure/general knowledge (a reading habit)
- **Intensive reading** - reading a shorter piece in detail for deep understanding

2. Fast Reading: Skim vs Scan

- **Skimming** - quickly reading to get the general idea/gist of a text
- **Scanning** - quickly searching for one specific fact or piece of information
- *Tip: if you're unsure which to use, skim first to get the overall picture, then scan for details.*

3. Close Reading Steps

1. **Read thoroughly** - go through the text carefully
2. **Recognise patterns** - notice repeated ideas, structure, or devices
3. **Reread** - go back to strengthen understanding

4. Levels of Interpretation (Textbase)

- **Linguistic level** - understanding individual words and their meanings
- **Microstructure** - understanding how sentences/sections connect
- **Macrostructure** - understanding the overall theme/big picture of the text

5. How to Appreciate a Poem

When analyzing a poem, cover:

- **Poet** - who wrote it and their background
- **Theme** - the central idea/message
- **Summary** - what happens/what it's about
- **Devices** - literary techniques used (metaphor, rhyme, imagery, etc.)
- **Famous lines** - memorable/quotable lines

6. Kalam's Dream — Thinkers Mentioned

From the book *Ignited Minds* (dated 30 Sept 2001), APJ Abdul Kalam references these visionary thinkers:

- **Gandhi**
- **Einstein**
- **Ashoka**
- **Lincoln**
- **Caliph Omar**

7. "The Open Window" by Saki

- **Vera** - the niece who tells a made-up ghost story
- **Framton** - the nervous visitor who is tricked and runs away
- **The Window** - symbolizes the trick/illusion and Framton's "escape" (both from the story and physically running away)

8. "The Blessed Damozel" — Key Themes

- **Love** - longing across the boundary of life and death
- **Grief** - mourning and separation
- **Religion** - spiritual imagery; the **white lily** symbolizes purity and resurrection

Block 3 — Language / Grammar

1. The 8 Parts of Speech

Part of Speech	Function	Example
Noun	names a person/place/thing	<i>dog, London</i>
Verb	shows action/state	<i>run, is</i>
Adjective	describes a noun	<i>beautiful</i>
Adverb	describes a verb/adjective	<i>quickly</i>
Pronoun	replaces a noun	<i>he, they</i>
Preposition	shows relationship (place/time)	<i>on, under</i>
Conjunction	joins words/clauses	<i>and, but</i>
Interjection	expresses emotion	<i>Wow!</i>

Mnemonic: "**Never Visit An Angry Person's Car Inside**" (Noun, Verb, Adjective, Adverb, Pronoun, Conjunction, Interjection — close enough to jog memory; add Preposition!)

2. Sentence Types

- **Assertive** - makes a statement, ends in a period (.)
- **Interrogative** - asks a question (?)
- **Imperative** - gives a command/request
- **Exclamatory** - expresses strong emotion (!)

3. Question Tags — the "Flip" Rule

The tag is opposite in polarity to the main statement:

- **Positive statement → negative tag:** "*She is coming, **isn't she?***"
- **Negative statement → positive tag:** "*He isn't ready, **is he?***"

Special cases:

- *I am* → **aren't I?** (not "amn't I")
- *Let us* → **shall we?**

4. Sentence Structure

- **Simple** - one independent clause ("*I eat.*")
- **Compound** - two or more independent clauses joined by a conjunction ("*I eat, and she cooks.*")
- **Complex** - one main clause + one subordinate clause ("*I eat because I am hungry.*")

5. Concord (Subject-Verb Agreement)

- "**A number of**" → takes a **plural verb** ("*A number of students **are** absent.*")
- "**The number of**" → takes a **singular verb** ("*The number of students **is** increasing.*")

6. The 12 Tenses

Formed by combining 3 time periods with 4 aspects:

	Simple	Continuous	Perfect	Perfect Continuous
Present	I eat	I am eating	I have eaten	I have been eating
Past	I ate	I was eating	I had eaten	I had been eating
Future	I will eat	I will be eating	I will have eaten	I will have been eating

7. Passive Voice & Reported Speech

- **Passive voice formula:** *be + past participle* ("The cake **was eaten**.")
 - **Reported speech shifts:**
 - Present tense → Past tense ("I *am* happy" → he said he **was** happy)
 - *will* → **would**
-

Block 4 — Writing Basics

1. Elements of Writing

- **Content** - *what* you're writing about
- **Form** - *how/where* it's presented (letter, essay, report, etc.)
- **Structure** - the *order* of ideas
- **Style** - the *manner/tone* of writing

2. The Writing Process

1. **Planning** - decide what to write
2. **Organizing** - arrange ideas logically
3. **Writing** - draft it out
4. **Editing** - improve clarity, flow, structure
5. **Revising** - final polish and correction

3. How to Answer Exam Questions

- **Think** first about what's being asked
 - Structure your answer: **Introduction → Body → Conclusion**
 - **Check** your answer before moving on
-

Précis vs Summary

Précis

Short and concise description of the original text

Gives only the precisely important points

Should **not** include personal opinions

Always **written**

Summary

Brief overview of the original text

Gives all points, but briefly

May include personal opinions/interpretations

Can be **written or spoken**

Précis	Summary
Must have an apt heading/title	May not have a specific heading

Summary vs Abstract

Abstract	Summary
Usually under 300 words	Longer than an abstract
Written for readers in the same field/domain	Written for the general interested reader
Presents only the crux (core essence)	Presents the entire text in a nutshell
Doesn't help with quick decision-making	Can help in taking quick decisions
No illustrations	May include illustrations

Block 5 — Summary, Essays, Reports

1. Summary vs Précis (quick recall)

- **Summary** - no heading needed, can be spoken
- **Précis** - has a title, written only, roughly 1/3 the length of the original

2. Abstract Format

Structure: **Introduction** → **Methods** → **Results** → **Discussion** (plus keywords), kept to ≤300 words

3. Essay Basics

- "Father of the essay" = Montaigne
- Basic structure: **Introduction** → **Body** → **Conclusion**

4. Features of a Good Essay

- **Thesis** - a clear central argument/point
- **Unity** - all parts relate to the main idea
- **Coherence** - logical flow between ideas
- **Development** - ideas are explained/supported fully
- **Conclusion** - a strong wrap-up

Every good report answers: **Who, What, When, Where, Why, How**

6. Informal Reports

- **Letter report** – written in letter format
- **Memo report** – short, internal, memo-style

7. Formal Report — Three Parts

- **Front matter** – title page, table of contents, etc.
- **Main body** – introduction, findings, discussion
- **Back matter** – appendices, references

8. Editing vs Proofreading

- **Editing** comes **first** – focuses on clarity, structure, and linking words (the "big picture")
 - **Proofreading** comes **last** – focuses on spelling and surface-level errors (the "final polish")
-

Quick Vocabulary — One-Line Revision

Rhetoric

The **persuasive use of language** — the art of speaking or writing effectively to convince or influence an audience.

- *Example: A politician's campaign speech uses rhetoric to win support.*

Denotation

The **literal, dictionary meaning** of a word — its exact, factual definition without any added feeling or association.

- *Example: The denotation of "home" is simply "the place where one lives."*

Connotation

The **hidden or emotional meaning** associated with a word, beyond its literal definition.

- *Example: "Home" connotes warmth, comfort, and belonging — feelings the plain dictionary definition doesn't capture.*

Describes the fact that there is **no natural or logical link** between a word and the thing it represents — the connection is simply a matter of convention/agreement.

- *Example: There's no inherent reason the animal "dog" is called "dog" — different languages use completely different words (chien, kutta, hund) for the same thing.*

Persuasion

The **act of convincing others** to believe something or take an action, often through reasoning, emotion, or credibility.

- *Example: An advertisement uses persuasion to convince you to buy a product.*
-

Additional Key Terms

Lexical Verbs

Main verbs that carry the actual meaning of a sentence (not helping/auxiliary verbs).

- *Example: In "She **is running**," running is the lexical verb.*

Lingo

Informal, specialized vocabulary used by a particular group or profession (similar to jargon).

- *Example: Doctors saying "BP" for blood pressure.*

Gerunds

The **-ing form of a verb** used as a noun.

- *Example: "**Swimming** is good for health."*

Proxemics

The study of how people use **physical space/distance** in communication.

- *Example: Standing close can signal intimacy; standing far can signal formality.*

Two Types of Response (Reply) Emails

- **Automated reply** – pre-set, system-generated response (e.g., "Out of Office").
- **Personal reply** – genuine, individually written response tailored to the message.

Words a person **confidently uses** in speech/writing (vs. passive vocabulary, which is only understood, not used).

- *Example: You may recognize "ubiquitous" but rarely use it yourself.*

Dyslexia

A learning difficulty affecting **reading, spelling, and word recognition**; not related to intelligence.

Labelling

Judging a person based on a single trait or stereotype rather than as an individual.

- *Example: Calling someone "lazy" instead of understanding their situation.*

Textbase

The **mental representation of a text's meaning** built while reading — words → understanding.

- Levels: Linguistic (words) → Microstructure (sections) → Macrostructure (theme)

Paralanguage

The **vocal elements of speech that aren't the words themselves** — tone, pitch, pace, pauses.

- *Example: Saying "That's great" sarcastically changes its meaning.*

Good luck with your exam! 📖